

ACCESSIBILITY CONFORMANCE REPORT

ADA & Section 508 Accessibility Audit

Internet Crime Complaint Center — ic3.gov
“Directing Your Complaint” Page

AUDIT DATE	May 24, 2026
CONFORMANCE TARGET	WCAG 2.1 Level AA
REGULATORY BASIS	Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act · ADA Title II
PAGE AUDITED	ic3.gov/Home/DirectComplaint — “Directing Your Complaint”
METHOD	Manual code & assistive-technology review (markup, ARIA, headings, focus, links)
REPORT STATUS	Final

About this report. This audit assesses the IC3 “Directing Your Complaint” page against WCAG 2.1 success criteria. Each finding is classified by severity, mapped to its governing criterion, and paired with a concrete remediation. A prioritized roadmap and recommended ongoing-testing program follow the detailed findings. This page is part of the same property assessed in prior IC3 audits and shares its USWDS foundation; several findings recur across pages and are best addressed at the template level.

SECTION 1

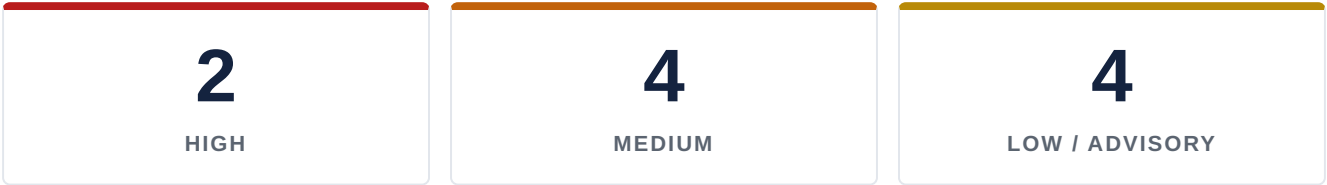
Executive Summary

The “Directing Your Complaint” page rests on a solid accessibility foundation. Built on the U.S. Web Design System (USWDS), it provides correct semantic HTML, a working skip link, a declared language, properly structured landmark regions, accessible social-media SVGs, and correct `aria-expanded` wiring on its navigation dropdowns and accordions. None of the issues identified require structural redesign.

The review found **ten issues, none critical but several worth prompt attention**. The two High-severity items are a broken heading hierarchy (a jump from `<h1>` straight to `<h4>`, plus a second `<h1>` in the footer) and a search submit button whose accessible name is computed fragily from a child image rather than declared explicitly. The Medium-severity cluster concerns control semantics — missing state on the mobile menu, a dialog without `aria-modal`, redundant adjacent home links, and an accordion whose checkbox icon contradicts its expand/collapse role. The remaining items are minor refinements and one AAA-level advisory.

All findings are remediable with targeted markup, ARIA, and minor CSS changes. Because this page reuses the shared IC3 header, footer, and modal, fixing the recurring items (heading levels, search button name, modal `aria-modal`, mobile-menu state) in the common templates will resolve them across the entire property at once.

Findings at a Glance



10 total findings on this page. Severity reflects user impact and likelihood of blocking comprehension or task completion, not engineering effort — all items are rated low-to-moderate effort.

Severity Definitions

SEVERITY	MEANING
High	A defect that materially impairs access for assistive-technology or keyboard users, or that violates a Level A/AA criterion in a way likely to disrupt orientation or task completion. Fix first.
Medium	A real barrier, ambiguity, or semantic mismatch that degrades the experience for affected users but generally has a workaround. Fix in the same remediation cycle.
Low / Advisory	A minor gap, consistency issue, or best-practice / AAA-level enhancement that improves clarity and robustness but is not a clear AA failure.

Detailed Findings

"Directing Your Complaint" page · 10 findings · 2 High · 4 Medium · 4 Low / Advisory

What's Working Well

- ✓ **Language declared.** `<html lang="en">` is present, enabling the correct screen-reader speech engine.
- ✓ **Descriptive page title.** "Directing Your Complaint — Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3)."
- ✓ **Working skip link.** `<a href="#main-content">Skip to content</a>` targets a real `#main-content` on `<main>`.
- ✓ **Landmark regions.** `<main>`, `<header>`, `<footer>`, two `<nav>` elements, and a `<search>` landmark are all present and properly structured.
- ✓ **Expand/collapse state.** All navigation dropdown buttons and accordion buttons correctly implement `aria-expanded`, and dropdowns correctly reference their regions with `aria-controls`.
- ✓ **Search field label.** The `<input type="search">` has an associated `<label>` via the `for` attribute.
- ✓ **Decorative images hidden.** Banner icons (U.S. flag, .gov icon, HTTPS lock) all carry `aria-hidden="true"`.
- ✓ **Accessible social icons.** Each social link uses an inline SVG with a `<title>` element supplying its accessible name.
- ✓ **Labeled dialog.** The Terms modal carries `aria-labelledby` pointing to a valid heading ID.
- ✓ **Dark-mode support.** A `@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark)` implementation is present.
- ✓ **Structured footer navigation.** Footer navigation regions use heading elements to label each column.

• High — Fix First

1 Broken heading hierarchy — H1 → H4 skip and a second `<h1>`

The page jumps directly from its `<h1>` (“I want to report...”) to `<h4>` for all four accordion section headings (“An Emergency,” “Child Exploitation,” etc.), skipping H2 and H3 entirely. In the footer, a second `<h1>` (“FBI”) appears. A page must expose exactly one `<h1>`, and the heading outline must not skip levels.

Observed outline: H1 → H4 ×8 → **H1** → H3 → H4 — a structure screen-reader users cannot navigate reliably.

Fix: Change the accordion section headings to `<h2>`. Re-level the footer brand headings (IC3, FBI, DOJ) to `<h2>`, and demote or remove the second footer `<h1>` (to `<h2>` or a styled `<p>`).

WCAG 1.3.1

Effort: Low

2 Search submit button has no explicit accessible name

The search form’s `<button type="submit">` has no text content and no `aria-label` or `aria-labelledby`. Its name is computed from a child `<img alt="Search">`. While this may work in some screen readers, the accessible-name computation is fragile, fails automated checks, and breaks if the image fails to load or the alt is removed.

Fix: Add `aria-label="Search"` directly on the `<button>` so the accessible name is explicit and unambiguous.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

• Medium — Should Fix

3 Mobile “Menu” and “Close” buttons lack `aria-expanded` and `aria-controls`

The mobile navigation “Menu” button and its “Close” counterpart have neither `aria-expanded` nor `aria-controls`. Screen-reader users cannot tell whether the navigation drawer is open or closed, and the relationship between the button and the region it controls is not communicated.

Fix: Add `aria-expanded` (toggled true/false by JavaScript) and `aria-controls` pointing to the navigation menu’s ID. The “Close” button should reference the same region or be the same toggling control.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

4 Terms modal has `role="dialog"` but is missing `aria-modal`

The Terms and Conditions modal is a `<div>` with `role="dialog"` and `aria-labelledby="fileTermsHeading"` — both correct — but `aria-modal="true"` is absent. Without it, some screen readers (notably NVDA + browser combinations) will not confine the virtual cursor to the dialog and will let users read content behind it. Focus should also return to the triggering control on dismissal.

Fix: Add `aria-modal="true"` to the dialog `<div>`, trap focus within it while open, and return focus to the “File A Complaint” trigger on close.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

5 Duplicate adjacent home links in the header

The header contains two consecutive links to `/Home/Index`: one wrapping the IC3 logo image (named “IC3 Logo”) and one with the text “Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3).” A screen-reader user encounters two adjacent links with different names pointing to the same destination — redundant and potentially confusing.

Fix: Wrap the logo and site name in a single `<a>`; or apply `aria-hidden="true"` to the image-only link and keep the text link; or give the image link an `aria-label` that clearly identifies it as the home link.

WCAG 2.4.4

Effort: Low

6 Accordion checkbox icon contradicts its expand/collapse semantics

The accordion items convey open/closed state with CSS checkbox icons (`check_box_outline_blank.svg` / `check.svg`). The `aria-expanded` wiring is correct, but the visual metaphor is a checkbox — which implies multi-select — rather than a standard expand/collapse control, creating a mismatch between visual affordance and semantic role.

Fix: Replace the checkbox icon with a standard chevron/caret, which universally signals expand/collapse. The ARIA is already correct; only the visual metaphor needs to change.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

• Low / Advisory — Consider Fixing

7 “File A Complaint” control lacks `aria-haspopup` / `aria-controls`

The “File A Complaint” item in the primary navigation is a `<button>` that opens the Terms modal rather than navigating to a URL. Using a button for an action is valid, but placed among anchor links it can surprise screen-reader users, and nothing announces that it opens a dialog.

Fix: Add `aria-haspopup="dialog"` and `aria-controls="[dialog-id]"` to the button so its purpose is announced.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

8 “Return to top” link uses `href="#"` with no focus target

The “Return to top” link uses `href="#"` rather than a dedicated anchor. The visible text is descriptive, but `href="#"` jumps to the top of the document without programmatically moving focus to a meaningful landmark.

Fix: Point the link at a real target such as `href="#top"` (adding `id="top"` at the page top), ideally a visible focus target with `tabindex="-1"` so focus moves correctly.

WCAG 2.4.4

Effort: Low

9 Accordion panels are inconsistent in how they are hidden

The accordion content panels (`#e911` , `#ncmec` , `#ic3`) use the `hidden` attribute when collapsed — correct, as it removes them from the accessibility tree. However, the `#ntoc` panel was absent from the DOM snapshot, suggesting an inconsistency in how panels are added or removed.

Fix: Ensure all four panels follow the same hide/show pattern consistently, so collapsed content is reliably removed from the accessibility tree.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

10 Abbreviations not expanded on first use

Acronyms such as `NTOC` and `SSL` appear in the Terms dialog, and `IC3` appears in headings, without expansion. WCAG 3.1.4 is advisory (Level AAA), but for a government site serving the general public, expanding abbreviations on first use aids comprehension.

Fix: Mark up first occurrences with `<abbr title="National Threat Operations Center">NTOC</abbr>`, `<abbr title="Secure Sockets Layer">SSL</abbr>`, and similar.

WCAG 3.1.4 (AAA)

Effort: Low

SECTION 3

Prioritized Remediation Roadmap

Findings are sequenced by user impact. Several items (heading levels, the search button name, modal `aria-modal`, and mobile-menu state) live in shared header, footer, and modal templates — fixing them once corrects every page on the property. Nearly all items are low-effort, code-level edits.

Phase 1 — High (fix first)

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
1	Repair heading hierarchy and remove the second <code><h1></code>	1.3.1	Low
2	Add an explicit accessible name to the search button	4.1.2	Low

Phase 2 — Medium

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
3	Add state attributes to the mobile menu controls	4.1.2	Low
4	Add <code>aria-modal="true"</code> and focus return to the modal	4.1.2	Low
5	Consolidate the duplicate header home links	2.4.4	Low
6	Replace the accordion checkbox icon with a chevron	4.1.2	Low

Phase 3 — Low / Advisory

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
7	Add <code>aria-haspopup</code> / <code>aria-controls</code> to “File A Complaint”	4.1.2	Low
8	Give “Return to top” a real focus target	2.4.4	Low
9	Make accordion panel hide/show consistent	4.1.2	Low
10	Expand abbreviations on first use	3.1.4 (AAA)	Low

SECTION 4

Ongoing Testing Program

This audit was a manual, code- and AT-level review of a single page. To sustain conformance as the site evolves — and because this page shares templates with the rest of the property — pair automated scanning with structured manual testing, and verify shared-component fixes across multiple pages.

LAYER	RECOMMENDED PRACTICE
Automated scanning	Run axe DevTools, WAVE, or axe-core in CI on this page and on every page that reuses the shared header, footer, and modal. Treat new violations as build-blocking regressions.
Keyboard-only testing	Tab through the navigation, accordions, and the Terms modal confirming visible focus, logical order, no traps, working skip link, and focus return on modal close.
Screen-reader testing	Validate with NVDA + Firefox and VoiceOver + Safari at minimum; add JAWS + Chrome where available. Confirm the corrected heading outline, dialog announcement, and accordion state.
Heading-outline review	After the Finding 1 fix, re-inspect the document outline to confirm a single <code><h1></code> and no skipped levels.
Template-level verification	Because fixes 1, 2, 3, and 4 affect shared components, re-test a representative sample of pages to confirm the corrections propagate site-wide.

Scope & disclaimer. This report reflects a point-in-time review of the IC3 “Directing Your Complaint” page as observed on the audit date. It does not constitute legal advice or a certification of compliance. WCAG conformance is determined per page and per process; remediating the findings herein advances — but does not by itself guarantee — full WCAG 2.1 AA, Section 508, or ADA Title II conformance across the entire property. Re-test after remediation and extend coverage to related pages and complete user workflows.